

KEY CHARACTERS *and* THEMES

~~Mr Birling~~

~~Mrs Birling~~

Sheila

Eric

Gerald

~~The Inspector~~

Eva Smith (?)

Guilt

Deceit and Secrecy

Social Class

(*similarly*) class divide

Social Responsibility / Personal Responsibility

Morality

Gender

Responsibility

~~Discovery of truth~~

(The crossed out have come up in the past. Mr Birling has come up *twice*.)

- Personally, I feel like it's not going to be secrecy nor guilt because they were on Macbeth so it would be a little weird.
- Sheila is possible, however, it's been characters for quite a few years in a row.

GENERAL

- AIC is assessed upon A01, A02 and A04. This does *not* include context (A03) like J&H, but knowing context will certainly elevate your analysis.
- Even though the play is set in 1912 (prior to WW1, WW2 and the sinking of the titanic), it was written for a post-war Edwardian society (1945). This creates *dramatic irony*.
- AIC is a **didactic** play that follows the conventions of 'The Well-made Play' of Eugene Scribe (19th century). The rough structure is:
 - Exposition, complication, climax, falling action and

resolution (which is left in suspense.)

- AIC also follows **THE GREEK UNITIES** which were derived from Aristotelian theatre (taken from *Poetics*)
 - *Action* – namely that the play should have one main action that it follows with few or no subplots. The actions seems more intense and convincing because there are no distractions from the main plot–line.
 - *Time* – the *action* should unfold under four and twenty hours (creates immediacy as events unfold in real–time)
 - *Place* – the *action* should take place in one location (no scene change), due to how the singular naturalistic setting should focus the attention of the audience.
- The play's INTENT could be multifaceted:
 - To entertain (a sociopolitical drama or moral fable, **widespread appeal** therefore because a lot of people watch theatre)
 - To change society (didactic message of the Inspector is that the WC suffers at the expense of the UC)

How the test looks

0 8 Write about Mr Arthur Birling in *An Inspector Calls* and how he is important to the play as a whole.

In your response you should:

- refer to the extract and the play as a whole
- show your understanding of characters and events in the play. [40]

**5 of this question's marks are allocated for accuracy in spelling, punctuation and the use of vocabulary and sentence structures.*

(and an extract)

For themes:

0	8
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An Inspector Calls

You are advised to spend about 45 minutes on this question.

You should use the extract below and your knowledge of the whole play to answer this question.

Write about the theme of responsibility in *An Inspector Calls* and how it is presented at different points in the play.

In your response you should:

- refer to the extract and the play as a whole
- show your understanding of characters and events in the play [40]

5 of this question's marks are allocated for accuracy in spelling, punctuation and the use of vocabulary and sentence structures.

ANALYSIS

- Specifically for AIC, a few adjustments need to be made to one's analysis.
- For instance, the key concept of **stagecraft** is integral to going up the grades. Stagecraft manifests itself in many ways:
 - Dramatic Irony (ostensibly *The Titanic*)
 - Stage Directions
 - Character dialogue (especially interrupts and more)
 - Props
 - Lighting and setting
 - Foreshadowing
 - The 'well-made play' structure
 - Tension
 - Cyclical (horrific) ending
- Remember, AIC is assessed for SPaG and sentence structures just as *Macbeth* was. Therefore, be careful!
- Stagecraft can best be analysed in the given the extract.
- Just spam the phrase 'Priestley uses stagecraft...' to help :)

It is important to note that Mr Birling has came up twice since the specification was made (once in 2018 I think and the other in 2024). This could mean that others come up (again), but I see this as unlikely.

MORE IMPORTANT STUFF

- When analysing, look past the character. Solely analysing the character is harmful to you, as they are all representations of a specific category. Birling represents the capitalist ideology, and so on.
 - Each character is an archetype of a wider theme. Therefore, analyse the theme, not the character. In reality, each character is basically a theme. For instance:
 - *"Write about Sheila and how she is presented...[40]"*
 - In the didactic play "An Inspector Calls", Priestley constructs the character of Sheila Birling to be as a representative of the younger generations of Edwardian society. By portraying Sheila as receptive to change, Priestley alludes to his hope for wider societal change that could manifest upon the hands of the younger generation: hope to destroy capitalism and harmful artificial class ideologies.
- Structure is KEY
 - Thesis
 - P1
 - P2
 - (could be anywhere) contextualise the extract
 - P3
 - P4 (and P5 but quality is better)
- ensure at least two for the extract and wider play each.
- make sure YOU EVALUATE AND RELATE TO THE WIDER PLAY AND SOCIETY otherwise you are in danger of losing marks.
- write a sentence/2 overview contextualising the extract saying where it is in the play.

Example essay structure

Sheila: (who is crying quietly) That's the worst of it.

Inspector: But just remember this. One Eva Smith has gone - but there are millions and millions and millions of Eva Smiths and John Smiths still left with us, with their lives, their hopes and fears, their suffering and chance of happiness, all intertwined with our lives, and what we think and say and do. We don't live alone. We are members of one body. We are responsible for each other. And I tell you that the time will soon come when, if men will not learn that lesson, then they will be taught it in fire and bloody and anguish. Good night.

He walks straight out, leaving them staring, subdued and wondering. Sheila is still quietly crying. Mrs Birling has collapsed into a chair. Eric is brooding desperately. Birling, the only active one, hears the front door slam, moves hesitatingly towards the door, stops, looks gloomily at the other three, then pours himself out a drink, which he hastily swallows.

In the detective play 'An Inspector Calls', JB Priestley leverages the role of the Inspector ostensibly to advocate for social justice by rejecting social injustice in all forms: ^{namely, the} ~~abstract~~ ^{abstract} ~~seeds and divisions~~ created of patriarchy, class and fiscal assets. ✓ 2

At the beginning of the play, Priestley uses stagecraft to introduce the Inspector in the stage directions as one who "who creates at once an impression of ^{namely, the} ~~renewed~~ ^{solidity} and purposefulness". Firstly, the Inspector is described as to "create" "creates..." an impression of... - the phrase "impression" is interesting as it suggests that the Inspector, in his human form looks like a fiction attributed to him, it is just an illusion created by the Inspector's ^{embodiment} by Priestley - this illusion is almost supernatural and as it is an illusion, it could apply to anybody who takes up the mandate of enforcing social justice. The ^{trickery} ~~trickery~~ is interesting, especially the adjective "purposefulness" which ^{ironically} suggests the ~~other~~ ^{other} characters (namely the ~~fitting~~ ^{fitting}) are not of any one true purpose ~~some~~ ^{some} ~~for~~ ^{for} capitalist ideology of ~~bona~~ ^{bona} self-benefit - fiscal endeavours have no purpose and no appeal to moral and social goodness - not present in the plays. Priestley ~~may~~ ^{may} have introduced the capitalist ideology to inform the audience that the true purpose of

Original intention

man lies in caring for his peers - ^{to} ~~be~~ a post-war audience
this message would resonate, namely that ^{the} human condition
and human life should be a priority, not economic
trifles. ~~It~~ ^{is} hardly.

Later on, the Inspector further outstings ~~his~~ ^{his} anti-capitalist
stance and favouring of social justice. This can be seen when
Arthur Birling exclaims that the working class need to be kept in
place or "they'd soon be asking for the world". The Inspector retorts
"It's better to ask for the world than to take it," ~~flipping~~
the blame back to the capitalist ideology - they have seized
the world and all in it at the expense of the "millions and
millions". There is ^{direct} contrast created between "asking" and
"take[ing]" which ~~emphasises~~ ^{emphasises} - the verb "ask" connotes the
humble desperation, beseeching and almost begging of the working
class - they are needy and ~~at~~ ^{subdued}. The verb "take"
likewise refers to the seizing of power almost destructively
with no consideration for the ramifications of such an
act on the working class. Overall, Priestley is portraying both
the victimised and marginalised against the few in power
who oppress and are not oppressed, and invites the audience
to side with one or the other - and there is only
one morally correct answer.

This extract is taken from Act Three and is the Inspector's
final speech, containing the final dialogue between him
and the Birlings. ^{By} ~~From~~ this point, all evil that
the Birlings committed against Eva Smith have been outlined,
putting the onus of responsibility on each person.

The Priestley narrative brings together the Inspector as the protagonist of social justice. Stagecraft is cleverly used by Priestley to portray the power dynamic - now overwhelmingly in the Inspector's favour. He insists that the Inspector is described to be "taking charge, masterfully" even despite the conflict between the two new divisions of his family says in its tracks. Despite being likely aged around middle class, the Birlochs are completely rendered mute - the abstract concept of class is shattered wholly proving its true value (namely that of suffering and suffering again.)

Later, the Inspector is described to be "possibly shutting up the notebook" - which may be deeply symbolic; the notebook may represent social injustice which is closed off completely. The word "possibly", however may reflect how social injustice is always being closed off (in the present) as the eternally conflict of lower and upper classes slowly is closed.

However, the advice "possibly", when taken literally, but relating to stage, the props reflects uncertainty - as in, the uncertainty of Priestley if social justice will be obliterated or forever maintained - and this lingering uncertainty is continued after the departure of the Inspector - capitalism resumes - but is sharply interrupted again by the telephone - the battle for social justice is mentioned with a seemingly infinite one with the brunt of responsibility lay upon the Secretary. Priestley knows may be attempting to plead with his 1948 audience to not fall into the "riot cycle" of class and patriarchy and injustice against each other and humiliation similar to what the Birlochs experienced.

In addition, the Inspector's message is portrayed as almost ~~begin~~ unorthodox, easy by nature! This can

be seen in the deliberately school-like imagery in the
 Inspector's closing speech, "we are members of one body"
 of men will not learn that lesson they will be brought
 out in fire and blood and anguish". The phrases "learn"
 and "brought" are simple ^{words} ~~messages~~ ^{words} and ~~follow to~~
 the ~~central~~ field of school. ~~and~~ ^{words} This may reflect
 that the Inspector's message is not deep and philosophical, or
 some ^{obvious} challenge - it is a trivial message so simple a
~~school~~ ^{school} child could grasp it. Through this, Priestley
 informs the audience that the ones of abolishing these
 morally bankrupt practices of patriarchy, class, wealth and
 there are simple to cast away and refusal to do so
 would make one intellectually beneath a child - resources
 are not ^{namely} for the bourgeoisie, but ~~rather~~ for every
 person, whether upper or lower class, rich or poor, man or
 woman.

$$35 + 5 = 40/40$$

EXAMPLE ANALYSIS

STEER

Social Class

THESIS

In the didactic play *An Inspector Calls*, Priestley presents the
 theme of Social Class as detrimental and illogical and this is
 perhaps to advocate for societal change in an Edwardian society, and
 by extension the wider world.

QUOTE

"but these girls aren't cheap labour- they're people (Sheila)"

ANALYSIS

Firstly, Priestley presents social class as a flawed construct. This is evident in Act One, where Sheila objects to the exploitation of the working class when she proclaims, "But these girls aren't cheap labour – they're people." To begin, the collective noun 'girls' is an interesting word choice, as the collective presents the exploitation of the working class as wide, prevalent and general. Moreover, the noun also connotes innocence and childishness, which makes the crimes of the Birlings, and by extension the upper class worse as they are portrayed to be wronging innocuous children. Furthermore, Priestley creates dramatic irony in the noun 'girls' as the speaker, Sheila is one herself – this reflects the divide in class between the upper and lower classes by how one group is virtually pampered whilst the other is forced to toil and labour. This is supported by the phrase, 'cheap labour', which Sheila rejects by the negation "aren't" – which is interesting as she indirectly benefits from this, suggesting the class divide is intuitively negative. To evaluate, Priestley may be doing this to inform the Edwardian audience against the dangers of the stupidity of the construct of class, which is so illogical that even the upper class (that benefit from it) recognise it.